DEEPA'S 90-DAY MANDATE

MESA · AI-Native Track · Term 2 Case Study

Deepa Nair is Head of Operations at Freshroots, a 200-person FMCG company that distributes packaged snacks and staples across Maharashtra and Goa. Freshroots is a regional brand - not a startup, not an MNC. They have grown steadily over 12 years, mostly through distributor relationships and trade margins.

Three weeks ago, Deepa's CEO returned from an industry conference. He called her into his office and said:

> *"Everyone at that conference was talking about AI. I don't want us to be the last ones. I want something running by Q1. You have ₹15 lakhs and 90 days."*

Deepa has no AI team. She has a 3-person IT team that manages the company's SAP ERP and one data analyst who produces weekly reports for leadership.

After a week of internal conversations - with her team, with functional heads, and with the CEO - Deepa has identified three areas worth investigating. She has put together a brief on each one. The briefs follow on the pages ahead.

Your Task

Using the 9-checks and the Pre-Build Decision Checklist, determine which of the three areas should be solved first.

Build the solution, end-to-end.

DEMAND PLANNING

Initiative Brief · Prepared by Deepa Nair, Head of Operations

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The Current State

Demand planning at Freshroots is a manual, monthly process. Raghav Kulkarni, the company's Senior Demand Planner, has been in this role for six years. Every month, he spends approximately two working days pulling sales and inventory data from SAP, running calculations in Excel, and producing a forecast for each of the company's 400 active SKUs across 1,200 distributors. His output feeds into procurement, which places orders accordingly.

The process runs on Raghav's judgment, built over six years of working with the same SKUs and the same distributor network. It is competent. It is also entirely undocumented.

The Problem

By the time Raghav's forecast reaches procurement, the data is already 3–4 weeks old. In a distribution business that moves fast during festival periods and reacts to competitor schemes, a monthly cycle misses demand shifts that a faster cycle would catch.

The impact: stockouts - SKUs that ran out before the next order arrived - cost Freshroots approximately ₹18–22 lakhs per quarter in lost sales. Overstock write-offs, primarily in perishable SKUs, cost another ₹10–12 lakhs. Demand planning errors cost the company ₹28–34 lakhs every quarter.

Raghav acknowledges the problem but says the cycle time is not the bottleneck - the manual data work is.

> *"If the data were already organised for me, I could run the same analysis twice a week."*

What Deepa Found

Deepa asked Raghav to spend two days documenting his forecasting logic. He produced the following rules:

- If an SKU's sales in the last 4 weeks are more than 20% above its 12-week average, flag as high-demand and recommend a reorder at 1.5x the standard quantity.
- If current stock falls below 6 weeks of average weekly sales, flag as stockout risk and recommend an immediate reorder.
- If current stock exceeds 14 weeks of average weekly sales, flag as overstock risk and recommend pausing the next order.
- Festival months - October, November, March - apply a 25% demand uplift before any threshold checks.

- High-perishability SKUs follow tighter windows: maximum 4 weeks of stock, minimum 3 weeks.

Raghav estimates that this logic governs approximately 80–85% of his monthly recommendations. The remaining 15–20% - new product launches, unusual distributor behaviour, one-off market events - he handles on judgment and cannot fully document.

Freshroots has three years of distributor-level sales data in SAP, which the IT team confirms can be exported as structured files. Purchase orders are managed in Zoho Inventory, which the procurement team uses alongside SAP.

DISTRIBUTOR SERVICE

Initiative Brief · Prepared by Deepa Nair, Head of Operations

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The Current State

Freshroots' 1,200 distributors communicate with the company through a 4-person customer service team, entirely over WhatsApp. The team handles 50–80 messages per day, spread across individual threads. There is no ticketing system, no query categorisation, no response time tracking, and no handoff protocol when a team member is on leave.

The Problem

Last year, Freshroots lost three distributors to regional competitors. Exit conversations with two of them cited poor responsiveness as a reason for switching.

In one case, a distributor in Nashik - a ₹28-lakh-per-year account - missed a promotional scheme because the CS rep responsible for his relationship forgot to send the notification. The registration window closed. The distributor found out afterwards. Over the following quarter, he reduced his monthly order volume by 30%.

Acquiring a new distributor costs Freshroots approximately ₹1.5–2 lakhs in field rep time, credit assessment, and onboarding. The average active distributor generates ₹18–25 lakhs in annual revenue. Distributor relationships are Freshroots' primary channel asset.

Deepa's working hypothesis - based on conversations with the CS team - is that 60–70% of inbound queries are repetitive questions with factual answers: order status, delivery ETAs, scheme eligibility, returns and credit note status. All of these have answers sitting in SAP.

What Deepa Found

When Deepa asked the CS team to pull together historical query data to validate the hypothesis, they found that no such data exists. WhatsApp conversations are not archived in any structured form. Query categories have never been defined. Response times have never been measured. The team's current resolution rate is unknown.

The CS team lead estimates that a typical day involves mostly routine queries, but has no data to support this. What she does know: when a query arrives at 7pm or on a Sunday, it waits until the next working morning.

OPERATIONS INTELLIGENCE

Initiative Brief · Prepared by Deepa Nair, Head of Operations

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The Current State

Every Monday morning, Priya Sharma - Freshroots' data analyst - spends four hours pulling data from SAP and assembling the weekly operations dashboard. The report covers 12 metrics: sales volume, order fulfilment rate, stockout incidents, overstock value, distributor complaints, and a handful of others. It is delivered to the CEO by noon. The format has not changed in two years.

The Problem

Three months ago, the CEO approved a ₹22 lakh raw material procurement on a Monday morning, based on Priya's weekly report. The report showed strong sales velocity and low inventory buffers - a clear signal to reorder.

That same week, on Wednesday, two large distributors reduced their order sizes, responding to a competitor's promotional scheme in three key markets. The signal landed in SAP that afternoon. No one in the procurement workflow monitors SAP daily - the team processes approvals once a week, acting on whatever Priya's Monday report said. The procurement order was placed on Thursday.

Priya's next report arrived the following Monday, flagging the distributor drops. By then, reversing the order cost more than absorbing the overstock. Write-off: ₹9 lakhs.

Deepa's framing of the problem:

> *"The CEO saw Monday's data on Monday. But so did procurement. The problem isn't who sees the data - it's that by the time anyone acts on it, the market has already moved."*

What Deepa Found

SAP holds two years of clean, consistently structured operational data. The 12 metrics in Priya's current report are well-defined and unambiguous. The IT team confirms the data pipeline from SAP to Excel is manual but straightforward.

Priya's four hours are not the bottleneck Deepa is trying to solve. The bottleneck is the weekly cycle - and, behind it, the question of who acts when a metric moves, and how fast.